8Cs of Effective Communication

Each C below gives its definition, the headings the slides place under it, and one example sentence.

1. Clarity

Definition: Being clear about your goal or message, and emphasizing one specific message or goal at a time rather than trying to achieve too much at once.

Headings in the slides:

- Bad Example / Good Example
- Tips on Clear Communication: choose precise words; choose short, familiar, conversational words; construct effective sentences and paragraphs; achieve appropriate readability and listening ability; include examples, illustrations and other visual aids
- Seven tips: (1) Consider your audience, (2) Say exactly what you mean, (3) Avoid jargon, (4) Keep it short and simple, (5) Ask for a playback, (6) Over-communicate, (7) Choose the right medium for the message
- 3W Feedback Model (under tip 2): **What** (describe the situation, specifically), **Why** (describe the impact), **Way** (describe the replacement behavior you want)

Example: "I wanted to write you a quick note about Daniel Kedar, who's working in your department." Naming the exact person removes the doubt that the bad example (just "Daniel") leaves.

2. Completeness

Definition: The communication must convey all facts required by the audience; the sender must consider the receiver's mind set and convey the message accordingly.

Headings in the slides:

- Bad Example / Good Example
- Tips on Complete Communication: the message should be complete and unambiguous; answer all questions asked, and give something extra when desirable; check the 5Ws and an H (Who, what, when, where, why and how)

Example: "The meeting will be at 10:00 a.m. in the second-level conference room." It supplies the time and place that the bad example ("the meeting we're having tomorrow") leaves out.

3. Conciseness

Definition: Communicating what you want to convey in the fewest possible words without forgoing the other Cs. Stick to the point and keep it brief.

Headings in the slides:

- Bad Example / Good Example
- Eliminate wordy expressions; include only relevant statements; avoid unnecessary repetition
- Tips on Concise Communication: Think Before You Speak; Main Idea First; Necessary Supporting Details Only; Use Meaningful, Descriptive Verbs; Focus on Your Audience

Example: "Our target market will want to know about the company's philanthropic efforts, especially our goals to become sustainable and help local schools." The filler words and repetition of the bad example are removed.

4. Concreteness

Definition: Communicating concretely means being specific, definite and vivid rather than vague and general. Include important details and facts, but nothing that deters the focus of the message.

Headings in the slides:

- Bad Example / Good Example
- Tips on Concrete Communication: use specific facts and figures; choose image-building words; avoid uncertainty

Example: "Just take a complete Lunchbox Wizard from your refrigerator each day to give your kids a healthy lunch and have more time to play or read with them!" Vivid detail replaces the vague "will save you time every day."

5. Consideration

Definition: "Stepping into the shoes of others": taking the audience's viewpoints, background, mind-set and education level into account, protecting their self-respect and emotions, and modifying your words to suit their needs.

Headings in the slides:

- Features of considerate communication: emphasize the "you" approach; empathize with the audience and show interest in them; show optimism, stressing "what is possible" rather than "what is impossible"
- Tips: keep the actual audience in mind; focus on "you" instead of "I" and "we"; show receiver benefit or interest in the reader; emphasize the positive, pleasant facts; apply integrity and ethics

Example: "Thanks for submitting the report. You can expect Finn's feedback by email." (The slides give no example for this C; this one was written for this summary to show the "you" approach.)

6. Correctness

Definition: Correct communication fits your audience and is error-free.

Headings in the slides:

- Bad Example / Good Example (two errors: "conservation" for conversation, "weak" for week)
- Tips for Correct Communication: the message is exact, correct and well-timed; check the precision of facts and figures; use appropriate and correct language; maintain acceptable writing mechanics; choose non-discriminatory expression

Example: "I enjoyed our conversation, and I'm sure that the two-week deadline won't be an issue." Both word errors of the bad example are fixed.

7. Courteous

Definition: Courteous communication is friendly, open and honest, with no hidden insults or passive-aggressive tones. You keep your reader's viewpoint in mind and are empathetic to their needs.

Headings in the slides:

- Bad Example / Good Example
- Tips on Courteous Communication: be sincere, thoughtful and appreciative; omit expressions that irritate, hurt or belittle; grant and apologize good-naturedly; use terms showing respect for the receiver; stay unbiased

Example: "I'd really appreciate it if you could give my team a little extra time each week to fully cover their progress reports." It asks politely where the bad example complains.

8. Coherent

Definition: The message has a logical flow: all points are relevant and consistent with the tone and flow of the text, so the reader does not lose track of what you conveyed.

Headings in the slides:

- Bad Example / Good Example
- Tips on Coherent Communication: **First Principle of Cohesion, Old First** (begin sentences with information familiar to your readers); **Second Principle of Cohesion, New Last** (end sentences with information readers cannot anticipate, the new, technical or difficult information)

Example: "Thanks for submitting the industry report. Finn will give you some feedback on it." The email stays on the report only; the unrelated meeting question is dropped.